

Ask people before we list them

Please read this and decide: should we build this or not?

This paper explains one proposed change to the KSIJ Travel Directory. It is written in plain words. No technical knowledge is needed.

WHAT WE DO NOW

Someone fills in the form to add a contact. That entry waits. A committee moderator reads it and approves it. Only then does it show on the site.

We do not ask the person whose number was added. We trust the person who submitted it.

WHAT WE ARE PROPOSING

When someone adds another person's number, the system contacts that person by itself. It sends them a WhatsApp message and, if we have their email, an email too. The message says:

*Your number was added to the KSIJ Travel Directory. Did you agree to this? **Yes** or **No**.*

Then:

- **They tap Yes** → the entry goes live on its own.
- **They tap No** → the entry is blocked and never shows.
- **They do not reply in 3 days** → a committee member decides, the way we do today.
- **They added their own number** → we do not message them.

THE BIGGEST RISK: WHATSAPP MAY SHUT US DOWN

This is the part to weigh most carefully.

WhatsApp has a strict rule. A business may only message people who agreed to hear from it first. Our plan does the opposite. It messages people who never agreed, just to ask them if they agree. That is the exact thing WhatsApp tries to stop.

Here is how a ban happens. Many people will get a message from a number they do not know. Some of them will tap **Block** or **Report spam**. WhatsApp counts these reports. If enough people report us, WhatsApp lowers our rating, then suspends our number, and can ban it for good.

If our number is banned:

- **The check stops at once.** No messages go out. The feature simply stops working, often with little warning.
- **We lose the number** we set up and verified.
- **Getting it back is slow, and often not possible.** We would have to start again with a new number and pass WhatsApp's checks all over.

Be clear on why this matters. This is not a small or rare risk. It is the most likely way this feature breaks, because the feature depends on doing the one thing WhatsApp punishes. The more we use it, the more strangers we message, and the higher the chance of reports and a ban.

Email and text message (SMS) do not have this problem. If the WhatsApp risk feels too high, we can send the consent request by email only, or by SMS, and keep the same Yes or No check.

WHAT CHANGES FROM TODAY

	Today	With this change
Who checks the person agreed	Nobody asks them	The person confirms it themselves
Committee work	Read and approve every entry	Only handle the ones with no reply
How fast an entry appears	After a moderator gets to it	Right after the person taps Yes
Who gets contacted	Nobody	The person whose number was added

THE GOOD

- **The person agrees for themselves.** That is the strongest kind of consent.
- **Less work for the committee.** Most entries approve themselves.
- **Entries appear faster.** No waiting for a moderator.
- **More trust and privacy.** We only list people who said yes.
- **A clear record.** We can show the person agreed, and when.

THE CONCERNS

- **WhatsApp may ban our number.** This is the biggest concern. It has its own section above, “The biggest risk”.
- **It can feel like spam.** We message people who did not ask to hear from us.
- **It costs money.** WhatsApp charges a small fee for each message. Email is free.
- **It can be misused.** Someone could put in a stranger’s number just to make the system message them.
- **No person checks a “Yes”.** When someone taps Yes, the entry goes live with no committee member looking at it.
- **Setup takes time.** WhatsApp requires a verified business account and message approvals before we can send anything. That is days of paperwork, not minutes.

WHAT IT COSTS

- **Email:** basically free.
- **WhatsApp:** a small fee per message, plus a verified WhatsApp business account. There is no way to send WhatsApp messages automatically for free.
- **Setup:** one-time effort to register the business account and get messages approved.

WHAT WE ASK YOU TO DECIDE

Do we build this, yes or no?

If yes, two choices are already set, and you can change them:

1. A **Yes** from the person publishes the entry automatically.
2. **No reply in 3 days** holds the entry for a committee member.

If you would rather keep a person checking every entry, or skip WhatsApp and use email only, say so. Both are possible and both cost less.